

"There are, of course, socio-cultural rigidities and bureaucratic hiccups that pose unique challenges for faculty system"

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ASSISTANT PROFESSOR, IIM KOZHIKODE



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SOURAV MUKHERJI
DEAN (FACULTY), IIM BANGALORE

Someone who has done his PhD in the US may lack contextual knowledge, he says. "We have a Centre for Teaching and Learning where we develop their teaching and help them start applied research in the Indian context."

INDIAN KNOWLEDGE

For decades, Indian B-schools relied heavily on theories, cases and frameworks developed in Western markets. They now want to add the Indian experience to these layers.

IIM Kozhikode's Sebastian says globally connected faculty can help B-schools build visibility through high-quality publications, global conferences, editorial roles, collaborative research and engagement with international institutions. But globalisation should not mean reproducing research agendas developed elsewhere, he says.

IIM Kozhikode describes the approach as "globalising Indian thought", turning the country's institutional innovations, organisational experiences and societal challenges into knowledge that matters globally. Digital public infrastructure, financial inclusion, platform businesses, entrepreneurship, healthcare delivery and AI adoption are some of the areas where research can be relevant far beyond India.

THE PULL FACTORS

The decision to return is not being driven by one factor. Compensation matters but so do academic freedom, research funding, infrastructure, teaching loads, career progression and institutional culture.

"As a public institution, our salaries are quite low. That is my biggest challenge in attracting faculty," says IIM-B's Mukherji. "We have tried some chair professorships. For example, every faculty member who joins gets something like a Young Faculty Chair, which supplements their income. But we cannot match the compensation that a private school can offer."

But there are other pull factors too. "IIM Bangalore has a beautiful campus. There is value in coming and settling down here with your future spouse and children. Some of these softer factors help."

Research support is another part of the proposition. "There are also a lot of research grants which can sometimes be difficult to access in the US. Here, the institute is quite flexible."

But the competition for talent remains real. "We often have a bright Indian PhD holder on the job market. But when we make an offer, and If Wharton or Harvard is also making him an offer, he may choose that. Our hit rate is not very high. But we live with that."

Agarwal says there is a real interest among Indian academics to return home driven by an improvement in India's academic environment as well as a desire to contribute to the country's education and research ecosystem.

Sobhanan points to three changes that have made a difference: the rise in the quality and global visibility of research from Indian institutions, stronger industry-academia collaboration and better funding opportunities. He also points to opportunities for faculty and PhD students, including the ANRF Prime Minister Early Career Research Grant he received this year.

The real test is retention. That will require research autonomy, funding, predictable career paths, and an intellectually stimulating environment.

The bigger opportunity is what Sebastian calls "brain circulation", enabling academics to build careers in India while remaining connected to global research networks.

"The future competitiveness of Indian B-schools will depend substantially on their ability to become talent magnets," says Sebastian. BT